

Primary Source Reading 2: The Categorical Imperative

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Immanuel Kant, Groundwork of the Metaphysic of Morals, translated by Thomas Kingsmill Abbott (1873)
Read before Lesson 14b: The Categorical Imperative

Before you read: Kant now states the principle his whole argument has been building toward, and immediately tests it on a hard case: is it ever permissible to make a promise you don't intend to keep? As you read, follow his reasoning carefully — the test he applies is not “would this hurt someone” but “could this maxim survive being made a universal law.”

Act Only on a Maxim You Could Will to Be Universal

But what sort of law can that be, the conception of which must determine the will, even without paying any regard to the effect expected from it, in order that this will may be called good absolutely and without qualification? ...There remains nothing but the universal conformity of its actions to law in general, which alone is to serve the will as a principle, i.e., I am never to act otherwise than so that I could also will that my maxim should become a universal law.

The False Promise

Let the question be, for example: May I when in distress make a promise with the intention not to keep it? ...The shortest way, however, and an unerring one, to discover the answer to this question whether a lying promise is consistent with duty, is to ask myself, “Should I be content that my maxim (to extricate myself from difficulty by a false promise) should hold good as a universal law, for myself as well as for others?” and should I be able to say to myself, “Every one may make a deceitful promise when he finds himself in a difficulty from which he cannot otherwise extricate himself?” Then I presently become aware that while I can will the lie, I can by no means will that lying should be a universal law. For with such a law there would be no promises at all, since it would be in vain to allege my intention in regard to my future actions to those who would not believe this allegation... Hence my maxim, as soon as it should be made a universal law, would necessarily destroy itself.

Treat Humanity Always as an End, Never as a Means Only

Rational nature exists as an end in itself. Man necessarily conceives his own existence as being so... But every other rational being regards its existence similarly, just on the same rational principle that holds for me: so that it is at the same time an objective principle, from which as a supreme practical law all laws of the will must be capable of being deduced. Accordingly the practical imperative will be as follows: So act as to treat humanity, whether in thine own person or in that of any other, in every case as an end withal, never as means only.

The Kingdom of Ends

By a kingdom I understand the union of different rational beings in a system by common laws... we can conceive a kingdom of ends, which on the preceding principles is possible. For all rational beings come under the law that each of them must treat itself and all others never merely as means, but in every case at the same time as ends in themselves. Hence results a systematic union of rational being by common objective laws, i.e., a kingdom which may be called a kingdom of ends... It is certainly only an ideal.

In the kingdom of ends everything has either value or dignity. Whatever has a value can be replaced by something else which is equivalent; whatever, on the other hand, is above all value, and therefore admits of no equivalent, has a dignity.

After you read: Notice how the false-promise case does the same work here that it did in Reading 1, but examined from a new angle. There, the question was about the motive behind the promise. Here, the question is whether the *maxim* behind it could survive being made into a universal practice — and separately, whether making the promise treats the other person merely as a tool for getting what you want. Kant thinks both tests give the same answer. As you read the lesson, test that claim on a case of your own.